

Session 6: Ezekiel Called as a Prophet

Key Takeaways

- Many biblical figures had dynamic encounters with God in prayer.
- Ezekiel is in exile outside of Eden, yet he has an encounter with the inside of Eden—the glory of Yahweh.
- Biblical characters face tests about eating or abstaining from food, recalling the test in the garden of Eden.
- Ezekiel passes his test and is sent as a prophet to the people.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 1:28b-3:9

Part 1

a 1:28b **And I heard** a voice **speaking**,
2:1 and he said to me:
“ **Son of a human** ,
b **stand on your feet**
c and I will **speak** with you.”
d 2 And the Spirit/breath came into me,
c' when he **spoke** to me,
b' **and she stood me on my feet**
a' **and I heard** him **speaking** to me.

3 And he said to me:
“ **Son of a human** ,
I am sending you to **the sons** of Israel,
to **rebellious** nations **who have rebelled** against me;
they and **their fathers** have betrayed me until this very day.

4 And **the sons** who are hard of face and hard of heart,
I am sending you to them.
And you shall say to them,
‘Thus says the Lord Yahweh!’

5 And as for them, **whether they hear or whether they refuse** —

because **they are a rebellious** house—
then they will know that a prophet has been in their midst.

⁶ And as for you **son of a human**,

a **do not be afraid of them,**
and do not be afraid of their words.

b Although they are thorns and barbs for you,
and you are sitting with scorpions,

a' **do not be afraid of their words,**
and do not be dismayed before them,

b' because they are a **rebellious** house.

⁷ And you shall **speak my words** to them,
whether they listen or whether they refuse,
because they are **rebellious**.

Part 2

⁸ Now you, son of a human,

A **listen to what I am speaking to you** ;
do not be **rebellious** like **that rebellious house**.
Open your mouth and eat what I am giving you."

⁹ Then I looked, and look:
a hand was extended to me;
and look, a **scroll** was in it.

¹⁰ And he spread **it** out before me,
and **it** was **written** on the front and back,

B and **written** on **it** were lamentations, mourning and woe.

^{3:1} And he said to me,
"Son of a human,
eat what you find;
eat this **scroll**,
and go, speak to **the house of Israel**."

² And **I opened my mouth**,
and **he made me eat** this **scroll**.

³ And he said to me,
"Son of a human,
A' **make your stomach eat**,
and **fill your innards** with this **scroll which I am giving you."**

And **I ate** it,
and it was sweet as honey in my mouth.

Part 3

A ⁴ And he said to me,
"Son of a human,
go to **the house of Israel**
and **speak with My words** to them.

B ⁵ For you are not being sent to a people of **deep of speech or heavy of tongue**,
but to **the house of Israel** you are being sent;
⁶ not to many peoples of **deep of speech or heavy of tongue**,
whose words you cannot understand.
Surely, had I sent you to them,
they would listen to you.

A' ⁷ But **the house of Israel** will not be willing to listen to you,
since they are not willing to listen to me,
because **the whole house of Israel** is **strong of forehead and hard of heart**.
⁸ Look, I have made **your face as strong as their faces**,
and **your forehead as hard as their foreheads**.
⁹ Like **diamond harder than flint I have made your forehead**;
do not be afraid of them,
and do not be dismayed before them,
for **they are a rebellious house**."

Ezekiel 1:28b-3:9. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021)

Ezekiel Called To Speak to Rebellious Israel by Eating the Scroll

In Ezekiel 2:2 (and Ezek. 3:12-14), the *ruakh* (Spirit) that animated the creatures (Ezek. 1:12, 20, 21) comes into Ezekiel and commissions him. Just as the living-beings were moved and driven by the *ruakh*, so now Ezekiel will be driven and moved as well. It's a powerful image of the prophet being seized by the divine will and word, whether or not he likes it.

In Ezekiel 2:3, Ezekiel is depicted as a new Moses sent to a rebellious audience who will resist his message.

Exodus 3:9-10 NASB

⁹ Now, behold, the cry of the sons of Israel has come to me; furthermore, I have seen the oppression with which the Egyptians are oppressing them. ¹⁰ Therefore, come now, and **I will send you to Pharaoh**, so that you may bring my people, the sons of Israel, out of Egypt.

Ezekiel 2:3-4 NASB

³ Then he said to me, "Son of man, **I am sending you** to the sons of Israel, to a rebellious people who have rebelled against me; they and their fathers have transgressed against me to this very day. ⁴ **"I am sending you** to them who are stubborn and obstinate children, and you shall say to them, 'Thus says the Lord God.'

The Test of Ezekiel's Obedience

Ezekiel eating the scroll ([Ezek. 2:8-3:3](#); see also [Jer. 15:16](#)) is commonly understood as Ezekiel symbolically "ingesting" his prophetic message so that he can go and announce it. But this interpretation confuses this scene with what follows, where he's commanded to take the divine word "into your heart ... and your ears" ([Ezek. 3:10](#)). This scene, in which Ezekiel internalizes the scroll of grieving, is Ezekiel's test (for this interpretation, see Margaret Odell, [Ezekiel](#), p. 44).

Ezekiel 2:8 Instructor's Translation

But you, son of a human,
hear what I am speaking to you;
do not be rebellious, like the rebellious house;
open your mouth and eat what I am giving to you.

Ezekiel's ordeal is clearly presented as a test that will set him apart from his rebellious contemporaries. To eat the divinely provided (and strange) food is to submit to the divine will and so separate himself from among the people.

This test finds a unique parallel with the testing ordeal of the adulterous wife in [Numbers 5:11-31](#).

Numbers 5:23-24 NASB

²³ 'The priest shall then **write these curses on a scroll**, and he shall wash them off into the **water of bitterness**. ²⁴ 'Then he shall make the woman drink the water of bitterness that brings a curse, so that the water which brings a curse will go into her and cause bitterness.

In this strange symbolic ordeal, the woman's guilt or innocence is established by her eating the words of a scroll of covenant curses. So here, Ezekiel is invited to eat the scroll of divine judgment. But his obedience brings about a surprising result. The lament scroll brings sweetness instead of bitterness.

This image is repeated in [Psalm 19:10](#) and [119:103](#), and makes us think this reflects the goodness of Ezekiel's personal encounter with Yahweh (note the reversal of this image in [Rev. 10:10](#)). But this sweet imagery is out of place here, as Ezekiel's experience is filled with fear, terror, and sorrow.

Israel is depicted as resistant, rebellious, and unable to listen to his message. The exile did not change their hearts; the exiled generation is perpetuating the same covenant rebellion of their fathers. The phrase "stiff of face and hard of heart" in [Ezekiel 2:4](#) and [3:7](#) echoes "stiff-necked" from [Exodus 32:9](#).

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 3:10-15

¹⁰ And he said to me,
“Son of a human,
all my spoken-words which I will speak to you,
take into your heart
and listen with your ears.

¹¹ **And walk (הלך), go (בוא) to the exiles,**
to the sons of your people,
and speak to them and say to them,
‘This is what Yahweh Elohim says ...’
whether they listen or not.”

a ¹² **And the ruakh lifted me up,**
b and I heard **the sound of a great quaking** behind me,
“Blessed be the glory of Yahweh from his place.”
c ¹³ And **the sound** of the wings of the living beings touching one another,
and **the sound** of the wheels beside them,
b' and **the sound of a great quaking.**
a' ^{14a} **And the ruakh lifted me up and took me away;**

^{14b} **and I walked (הלך),** bitter, in the hot-anger of my **ruakh,**
and the hand of Yahweh was strong on me.
¹⁵ **And I went (בוא) to the exiles** at Tel-Aviv,
those lived beside the river Chebar,
and I sat there seven days, displaying shock, in their midst.

Ezekiel 3:10-15. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Ezekiel Deposited Back Home—Really Worked Up

After Ezekiel’s commissioning is over, he hears one last command to go back to his community of exiles (that echoes the opening call in [Ezek. 2:1-8](#)). As he is “lifted up by the *ruakh*, he hears a sound/voice” (which he also heard back in [Ezek. 1:24-25](#)), that he describes in three ways.

1. A quaking of the land
2. An audible announcement of blessing and praise
3. The sound of the divine chariot moving

The second element above, the announcement of blessing on the divine presence, is fascinating. There is no preparatory context for this announcement, no mention of who says it to whom. It is, however, similar to a

doxology found in [Psalm 135:21](#).

Psalm 135:21 NASB*

Blessed be Yahweh **from Zion**, (מצִיּוֹן)
who dwells in Jerusalem. Praise the LORD!

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ezekiel 3:12 NASB*

Blessed be the glory of Yahweh **from its place** (ממקומו).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The idea that Yahweh receives praise “from Zion” implies an unmentioned group of those offering up the praise (i.e., from the inhabitants of Zion). The question, then, is whether “from its place” in [Ezekiel 3:12](#) means the same thing.

The phrase “from its place” could mean: (a) that the glorious presence of Yahweh is to receive blessing and praise that comes from its place (i.e., the temple, as in [Ps. 135:21](#)), or (b) that the glory of Yahweh is in fact still blessed, even though it is displaced from its proper home in the temple, “away from its place.”

Option (b) makes much more sense as a climactic conclusion to Ezekiel’s vision.

“... God’s glory is blessed wherever it is, even if it is not in the temple. The temple no longer exists [as a place of proper worship], but God’s glory can nevertheless be seen and praised. ... God can be praised here and now among the exiles in the same manner that he was once praised from Zion ... The once fixed place for God’s presence and appropriate praise in the temple has given way to the open in heaven.”

Schafer, Peter (2009). [The Origins of Jewish Mysticism](#). Princeton University Press. 49.

In contrast to the above approaches to [Ezekiel 3:12](#), many scholars note the oddity of the sudden doxology in context, because the noise is explicitly identified as the commotion caused by the wings and movements of the divine chariot (as in [Ezek. 1:24-25](#)). And so scholars follow the suggestion of Ferdinand Hitzig (*Der Prophet Ezechiel*, 1847) and Samuel David Luzzatto in emending the text in the following way: Instead of *baruk* (ברוך), “blessed be,” they proposed the text originally read *barum* (ברום), “when it rose.” And while the two words don’t look entirely similar in medieval square Hebrew font, they would have looked nearly identical in paleo Hebrew, in which Ezekiel would have written. Below is a comparison in Hebrew script from the 7th century Judean Lachish letters.

Blessed Be in Paleo Hebrew	When It Rose Up in Paleo Hebrew
“ Blessed be the glory of Yahweh from its place”	“ When the glory of Yahweh rose up from its place”
“blessed be” <i>baruk</i>	“when it rose up” <i>barum</i>
<i>Baruk vs. Barum</i> . Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).	




Baruk vs. Barum. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Ezekiel sits stunned for seven days (Ezek. 3:14-15); exactly the number of days his ordination into the priesthood would have lasted (Exod. 29:35). Instead he is ordained for a very different kind of commission that disturbs him deeply.

Key Themes in Ezekiel 1-3

Yahweh's glory appears outside the Jerusalem temple, near a slave camp in Babylon (!). Two implications: (1) Yahweh has effectively abandoned Jerusalem and its temple; (2) Yahweh's glorious presence can be with his people anywhere because, as the vision makes symbolically clear, the entire cosmos is the temple of Yahweh.

"The God who appears to Ezekiel is ... the God of the cosmos, who is not confined to the boundaries of the temple. To be sure, the Jerusalem temple is not yet destroyed when Ezekiel sees his vision of God as ruler of the entire cosmos (in 592 B.C.E.), but it will be destroyed soon (in 586 B.C.E.), and it is one of the major tasks of the newly appointed prophet to announce this very thing. The vision anticipates what will happen soon, and its message is not only that God reveals himself outside the land of Israel, but that God reveals himself outside the temple. God does not need the temple ... just as he did not need the temple in the distant past ... The entire cosmos is his temple."

Schafer, Peter (2009). [*The Origins of Jewish Mysticism*](#). Princeton University Press. 50.

Yahweh has gone into exile with his people, and he has chosen to reveal himself to a remnant there, from which he will "resurrect" (as in Ezek. 37) a renewed covenant people. Yahweh declares that it is among the repentant exiles that he has become "a temporary/little sanctuary" (see Ezek. 11:16), and that from these exiles he will restore a new Israel that will experience the promises of renewal explored in Ezekiel 34-48 (see Ezek. 11:17-20).

"God himself has become a 'small sanctuary' to the people of Israel during their exile, when the temple is destroyed. God is no longer bound to the land of Israel or to its temple. Wherever he is, the temple is with him. To be sure, the temple will be rebuilt, and God will then return to it. But for the time being ... what better substitute could there be for the temple than God himself."

Schafer, Peter (2009). [*The Origins of Jewish Mysticism*](#). Princeton University Press. 51.

Ezekiel's contemporaries resist his message and find it unwelcome, and the problem is their hard hearts (Ezek. 2:3-4, 3:7). This first description of the source of Israel's rebellion is key to the message of the book.

By framing the exiles' resistance to Ezekiel's message in this way, the present generation of Israel is depicted on analogy to the wilderness generation and to Pharaoh, the king of Egypt in the Torah. Both characters are described as having hard and resistant hearts to the message of Yahweh.

Pharaoh	Exiles
Exodus 7:13-14 ¹³ Yet Pharaoh's heart was hard (חזק + לב), and he did not listen to them, as the LORD had said. ¹⁴ Then the LORD said to Moses, "Pharaoh's heart is hard (כבד + לב); he refuses to let the people go.	Ezekiel 2:4 I am sending you to them, sons who are stiff of face (קשי פנים) and hard of heart (הזקי לב), and you shall say to them, 'Thus says the Lord God.' Ezekiel 3:7 yet the house of Israel will not be willing to listen to you, since they are not willing to listen to me. Surely the whole house of Israel is hard of forehead (חזקי מצח) and stiff of heart (לב קשי).
Exodus 32:8-9 ⁸ "They have quickly turned aside from the way which I commanded them. They have made for themselves a molten calf, and have worshiped it and have sacrificed to it and said, 'This is your god, O Israel, who brought you up from the land of Egypt!'" ⁹ The LORD said to Moses, "I have seen this people, and behold, they are a people stiff of neck (קשה ערף) .	
<i>Pharaoh's Hard Heart. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).</i>	

Notice how in 2:4 the descriptions of both Pharaoh and the wilderness Israelites are used to describe the exiles, but then in 3:7-8 the phrases are blended and combined, so that the exiles are truly a combination of Pharaoh and the generation of the golden calf.

This portrait of the exiles as similar to Israel in the wilderness, while clearly negative, is also hopeful. Because it was precisely the hard hearts of the wilderness generation that led Moses to hope in the reversal of their condition. If Israel is ever to be faithful to the covenant with Yahweh, it will result from a divine initiative of mercy.

Deuteronomy 30:1-2, 4-6 NASB*

¹ So it shall be when all of these things have come upon you, the blessing and the curse which I have set before you, and you call them to mind in all nations where Yahweh your *Elohim* has banished you, ² and you return to Yahweh your *Elohim* and you **listen to his voice with all your heart and being** according to all that I command you today, you and your sons ...

⁴ If your outcasts are at the ends of the land, from there Yahweh your *Elohim* will gather you, and from there he will bring you back. ⁵ Yahweh your *Elohim* will bring you into the land which your fathers possessed, and you shall possess it; and he will prosper you and multiply you more than your fathers. ⁶ Moreover Yahweh your *Elohim* **will circumcise your heart and the heart of your descendants, to love Yahweh your *Elohim* with all your heart and with all your being, so that you may live.**

Ezekiel's prophetic experience is largely private and marked by symbolic actions and bizarre behavior: overwhelming vision (Ezek. 1), eating a funeral scroll (Ezek. 2:9-3:2), stunned into silence (Ezek. 3:14-15), recluse in his house (Ezek. 3:24-27).

Ezekiel's Eden in Exile



Ezekiel's Eden in Exile. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

What role do you think prayer and Scripture play in the lives of God's people? Do you see them as means of encountering God? Why or why not?